Polish Assignment Documentation

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This document will hold my design choices and testing data surrounding the Polish Sidequest.

For this assignment, I tried to focus the most on polishing what was already there, instead of adding new things. Subjects like menu's, animations et cetera I tried to avoid, focussing more on changing the feel of the game to match the fantasy.

Itch link: https://jadeg5522.itch.io/runaway-on-the-battlefield

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The Fantasy

I was asked to create a simple statement that captured the fantasy and feel I would be working towards. I came up with the following after playing the game myself:

> *"The player pisses of a fleet of spaceships"*

This is very simple, but captures the basic feel I got from playing the game. Now to improve this feel to match the fantasy, by adding more polish to the game.

To help with this, I was asked to come up with three verbs that encapsulate this fantasy so I can center my changes around them.

Verb 1: Battlefield

The game already has it so that other ships can damage each other, making it a true battlefield where the player is not the only one getting hurt. The player just happened to piss off all the other spaceships so much that they are focussing their attacks on them.

I want the following change(s) surrounding this verb:

1) **Increase readability of the game**

make the battlefield more visible, currently it's only partially visible. This is to make the game more strategic instead of reaction based, with broader vision you can plan your moves better.
To balance the full FOV you get in this case, I made it so that the attacks and enemies only show up within the square. This way the difficulty of the game will stay about the same.

Aside from this, having the camera stuck in place instead of attached to the player will also make the game more strategic, aside from helping to not trigger my motion sickness (which it was definitely doing before).

2) **Instill the feeling of a battlefield**

First of all, adding a soundtrack will increase the feeling of the player being on a battlefield. One with energy will also help with our second verb, On the run.

(added after first test) Adding a background to reflect a battlefield will give a clearer view of where the battle is taking place.

Verb 2: On the run

Pissing off the entire fleet may have not been the brightest idea, seeing as your ship cannot handle more than 1 attack.

I want the following change(s) surrounding this verb:

1) **Adjust player movement**

Making player movement feel more snappy, so that the player feels more in control of their ship. This works together with previously mentioned changes, to make the game feel more like a strategic game than a reaction-based one.

Verb 3: Strategy

Now that you're in this situation, you need to strategically move to survive as long as you can.

I want the following change(s) surrounding this verb:

1) **Timer**

Give the player a sense for how long they've lasted so far.

Other changes also work towards this goal, like readability and player movement.

Testing

Test 1

This test was taken after changing player movement, adding a soundtrack and the visible map.

Hypotheses before start:

1) *The soundtrack will feel upbeat and energetic, fueling the same response from the players.*
2) *The movement will be easily picked up, since it reacts quickly to the users input and will be felt as snappy.*
3) *The battlefield will be easy to read, thanks to the change we made to make the FOV bigger.*

Notes:
The player had no history with shooter/spaceship games, so there was some confusion at the start. They picked up the controls rather quickly. Died a few times at the beginning. Seemed to like the soundtrack, as they tapped their foot along the beat.

Feedback given:

1) Having only one life makes the stakes high
2) Movement feels fast, but the tester felt very in control of the ship.

When asked if the fantasy was clear, they answered that the pissing off part was clear, but it wasn't clear that this was taking place on a battlefield.

Good:

The player enjoyed the soundtrack.
The player moved around the map well, only bouncing into the edges and getting cornered once.

Bad:

The feeling of a battlefield was not clearly shown.

Conclusions:

Focusing only on gameplay polish has not been enough to give the "battlefield" feeling, adding a background reflecting this might be a good idea to give the fantasy a clearer feel.

Test 2

This test was taken after adding the timer and a new background.

Hypotheses before start:

1) *The feeling of a battlefield will be clear to the player, because on top of all the things we have already mentioned, a background has now also been added.*
2) *A timer will give the players a feeling of how long they have been going, giving them a goal and making them want to last longer each time they replayed.*

Notes:
Tester is used to playing games, having played in various genres. Picked up the movement pretty quickly. Got surprised by the later enemies when they were first introduced, and had particular problems with the Blinkwolf (cyan enemy).

Feedback given:

1) Enemies are challenging, requiring a lot of focus to play around
2) It was fun to try and last longer each time, seeing as some enemies only showed up later. It kept the game feeling fresh even on the third try.
3) It would be nice if I could see my previous time on my next run.

When asked about the fantasy of the game and if it was clear to him, he answered with the following:

- Space background showed off that theme very well
- The music felt maybe a tad bit too upbeat, but wasn't fully out of place either. It was very energetic and fun.
- The pissed of enemies were very clear, it was fun to try and make them hit each other.

Good:

The feel seems to be good for the fantasy, the space battlefield theme was also clear. The timer made the progress the player made more tangible.

Bad:

Not being able to see your previous score or your highscore. Player pointed this out

Conclusions:

Adding a high score feature and having this visible on the next try is a good idea.

Next Steps

From my second test it was clear that the feel of the game matched the fantasy, but there were still some things to work on.

The largest point of this being to add a highscore system and having this be visible on the screen on later runs.

Aside from this, making player feedback like sound effects and particles can also still be added, making the feel even more clear.

References

Assets

Soundtrack: Hammer of Justice - made by Toby Fox 2025

Background: Space Images & Pictures. (n.d.). Pixabay. https://pixabay.com/images/search/space/